

13 The past perfect simple

English uses the past perfect simple with the past simple to talk about two or more events that happened at different times in the past.

See also:

Past simple **7** Present perfect simple **11**
Past perfect continuous **14** Participles **51**

13.1 THE PAST PERFECT SIMPLE

When talking about two events that happened at different times in the past, the past simple describes the event that is closest to the time of speaking. The past perfect describes an event further back in the past.

PAST PERFECT SIMPLE PAST SIMPLE

The train **had left** before we **arrived** at the station.



8:10PM



8:20PM

NOW

Pablo **had gone** to work when I **knocked** on his door.



7:00AM



7:30AM

NOW

HOW TO FORM

Use "had" followed by the past participle to form the past perfect.

SUBJECT

"HAD"

PAST PARTICIPLE

REST OF SENTENCE

The train

had

left

before we arrived at the station.

"Had" does not change with the subject.

The past participle expresses the action in the past.